Merriah A. Croston, PhD, MPH

Yerby Postdoctoral Fellow, Department of Social and Behavioral Sciences
Harvard T.H. Chan School of Public Health
Research Fellow, Division of Population Sciences, Dana-Farber Cancer Institute
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Curriculum Vitae | Updated November 2026

ACADEMIC POSITIONS

Yerby Postdoctoral Fellow 2025–present
Harvard T.H. Chan School of Public Health, Department of Social and Behavioral Sciences
Mentor: K. Viswanath, PhD

Research Fellow 2025–present
Dana-Farber Cancer Institute, Division of Population Sciences
Viswanath Lab

EDUCATION

PhD, Public Health Sciences 2025
Washington University in St. Louis
Dissertation: *Old Frames on New Media: Health Misinformation in Black Digital Communities*
Committee: Jenine Harris (chair), Douglas Luke, Matthew Kreuter, Ruopeng An, Raven Maragh-Lloyd

MPH, Epidemiology 2014
Emory University

BS, Biology 2006
Georgetown University

RESEARCH INTERESTS

I study how communication environments shape health beliefs and behaviors, and how to design communication interventions that work for the people who need them most. My current work applies these questions to cancer prevention, characterizing cancer-related communication environments and how they shape beliefs and behaviors. I aim to extend this work across the cancer prevention and care continuum and to translate these insights into digital-technology-enabled communication interventions. I take a mixed methods approach, and my work sits at the intersection of health communication and health equity.

PUBLICATIONS

Peer-Reviewed Journal Articles

Irie W., **Croston M.**, Mahone A. The impact of providers as health discussants on Black women's interest in PrEP for HIV prevention. *Journal of the International Association of Providers of AIDS Care*. 2024; 23: 1–7.

Thompson T., Coats J., **Croston M.**, Motley R., Sanders Thompson V., James A., Johnson L. "We need a little strength as well": Examining the social context of informal caregivers for Black women with breast cancer. *Social Science & Medicine*. 2024; 342: 116528.

Thompson T., Coats J., **Croston M.**, Motley R., Colditz G., King A., James A. An exploration of the needs and experiences of informal caregivers for Black breast cancer patients. *SSM – Qualitative Research in Health*. 2022; 2: 100097.

Garg R., **Croston M.**, Thompson T., McQueen A., Kreuter M. Correlates of smoking discarded cigarettes in a sample of low-income adults. *Addictive Behaviors*. 2022; 128: 107237.

Harris J., **Croston M.**, Hutti E., Eyler A. Diversify the syllabi: Underrepresentation of female authors in college course reading. *PLOS ONE*. 2020; 15(10): e0239012.

Thompson T., McQueen A., **Croston M.**, Luke A., Caito N., Quinn K., Funaro J., Kreuter M. Social needs and health-related outcomes among Medicaid beneficiaries. *Health Education & Behavior*. 2019; 46(3): 436–444.

Rabarison K., **Croston M.**, Englar N., Bish C., Flynn S., Johnson C. Measuring audience engagement for public health Twitter chats: Insights from #LiveFitNOLA. *JMIR Public Health and Surveillance*. 2017; 3(2): e34.

Hudson D., Kaphingst K., **Croston M.**, Blanchard M., Goodman M. Estimates of mental health problems in a vulnerable population within a primary care setting. *Journal of Health Care for the Poor and Underserved*. 2016; 27(1): 308–326.

Fell G., Munson A., **Croston M.**, Rosenwald A. Identification of yeast genes involved in K^+ homeostasis: Loss of membrane traffic genes affects K^+ uptake. *G3: Genes, Genomes, Genetics*. 2011; 1(1): 43–56.

Manuscripts Under Review & Preprints

Croston M., Piombo S., Dhawan D., Mohanty S., Minsky S., Maldonado-Campos A., Petro G., Frazier L., Viswanath K. Source-specific vaping information exposure, harm and benefit beliefs, and vaping outcomes across diverse U.S. adolescents. *Journal of Health Communication*. Submitted.

Croston M., Wang O., Harris J. A scoping review of literature on health misinformation and Black communities in the United States. Submitted.

Kikut-Stein A., Mohanty S., Mahtani S., Minsky S., Maldonado-Campos A., Li K., **Croston M.**, Fredericks M., Marte J., Adamic M., Frazier L., Viswanath K. Are we getting the message? Contextualizing youth health information exposure measurement with ecological momentary assessment and participatory action research. *Journal of Health Communication*. Revised and resubmitted.

Croston M., Harris J. The spread of fact-checks and the myths they debunk on Twitter: A case study of the graphene oxide myth during the COVID-19 pandemic. *JMIR Preprints*. 06/03/2025: 73538. Preprint.

FELLOWSHIPS & RESEARCH FUNDING

Yerby Postdoctoral Fellowship 2025–present
Harvard T.H. Chan School of Public Health

Tech Impact Network Dissertation Fellowship 2022
Center for Critical Internet Inquiry, University of California, Los Angeles

Chancellor's Fellowship for Graduate Studies 2017–2025
Washington University in St. Louis, Graduate School of Arts and Sciences

Spencer T. & Ann W. Olin Fellowship for Women 2017–2025
Washington University in St. Louis, Graduate School of Arts and Sciences

Grants Submitted / Under Review

Between Doom and Health: Mapping Climate-Risk Communication Ecologies in Black Communities Across Urban, Suburban, and Rural Massachusetts 2026
Salata Institute for Climate and Sustainability Seed Grant Program, Harvard University
Role: Co-PI (PI: K. Viswanath, PhD). $25,000 requested. Under review.

HONORS & AWARDS

Travel Award, Association of Internet Researchers Annual Conference 2023

Travel Award, International Network for Social Network Analysis, Sunbelt Conference 2022, 2023

1st Place, Three Minute Thesis (3MT) Competition 2022
Washington University in St. Louis, Graduate School of Arts and Sciences

Graduate Student Award 2021
The Association of Women Faculty, Washington University in St. Louis

PRESENTATIONS

Invited Talks

Croston M. (2026, August). *Say it so it lands: The science of peer-to-peer health messaging on social platforms and how to design messages that work*. UMB/DF-HCC U54 Outreach Core Science Café, Chelsea, Massachusetts.

Croston M. (2026, June). *Leveraging your research skills for health communication: A practical guide for early career investigators*. Writing retreat for Early Stage Investigators, Maternal and Child Center of Excellence, Harvard T.H. Chan School of Public Health (virtual).

Croston M. (2025, October). *Health (mis)information & social media: At the intersection of people, platforms, and networks*. Communication for Public Health Researchers panel, Society for Epidemiologic Research Student & Postdoctoral Committee (virtual).

Croston M., Gershon R., Cryder C. (2019, March). *Risky business: The risk-reward trade-off is different for nonprofit and for-profit firms*. Spencer T. and Ann W. Olin Fellowship for Women's Spring Research Symposium, St. Louis, Missouri.

Croston M., Rabarison K. (2016, June). *Public health, Twitter chats, and evaluating participant engagement: A case study*. CDC/NCCDPHP Division of Population Health Scientific Workgroup meeting, Atlanta, Georgia.

Rabarison K., **Croston M.** (2016, May). *How to measure public health Twitter chat participant engagement*. CDC/NCCDPHP Training Workgroup meeting, Atlanta, Georgia.

Croston M., Shaw C., Rabarison K., Bish C., Lebow-Skelley E., Henry D., Massoudi M. (2016, January). *An exploratory study of CDC's Prevention Research Centers, NCCDPHP's Four Domains, and partnerships with local, state, and tribal health departments*. CDC/NCCDPHP/DPH Applied Research & Translation Branch meeting, Atlanta, Georgia.

Refereed Conference Presentations

Croston M., Piombo S., Dhawan D., Mohanty S., Minsky S., Maldonado-Campos A., Frazier L., Viswanath K. (2026, October). *Source-specific vaping information exposure, harm and benefit beliefs, and vaping outcomes across diverse U.S. adolescents*. 19th American Association for Cancer Research Conference on The Science of Cancer Health Disparities, Atlanta, Georgia.

Croston M. (2026, October). *Platform repertoires and co-use ecologies: An intersectional account of social media platform use among White, Black, and Hispanic adults in the U.S.* Association of Internet Researchers Conference, Mexico City, Mexico.

Croston M. (2026, July). *Platform repertoires and co-use ecologies: An intersectional account of social media platform use among White, Black, and Hispanic adults in the U.S.* 12th International Conference on Computational Social Science, Burlington, Vermont.

Croston M. (2026, June). *Platform repertoires and co-use ecologies: An intersectional account of social media platform use among White, Black, and Hispanic adults in the U.S.* International Network for Social Network Analysis 46th Sunbelt Conference, Daytona Beach, Florida.

Kikut-Stein A., Mohanty S., **Croston M.**, Mahtani S., Li K., Maldonado-Campos A., Minsky S., Grullon Rojas A., Marte J., Adamic M., Frazier L., Viswanath K. (2026, April). *Integrating ecological momentary assessment and participatory action research to develop measures of youth health information exposure*. Kentucky Conference on Health Communication, Lexington, Kentucky.

Croston M. (2024, December). *"Black people cannot get coronavirus" and other myths: A social network analysis of COVID-19 misinformation diffusion on Black Twitter*. Promoting Research in Social Media and Health Symposium, San Francisco, California.

Croston M. (2023, June). *The effects of health departments' ego networks on information diffusion during a public health crisis: Twitter as a case study*. International Network for Social Network Analysis 43rd Sunbelt Conference, Portland, Oregon.

Croston M. (2022, November). *Twitter's Birdwatch: A case study of crowd-sourced and community-based fact-checking*. 20th Annual Community Informatics Research Network Conference, Prato, Italy.

Croston M., Harris J. (2022, July). *Misinformation versus fact-checks: Comparative analysis of COVID-19 vaccine-related retweet networks*. International Network for Social Network Analysis 42nd Sunbelt Conference, Cairns, Australia.

Croston M., Harris J. (2022, June). *What's in a jab?: The spread of COVID-19 vaccine misinformation versus fact-checks on Twitter*. useR! Conference.

Thompson T., Coats J., **Croston M.**, Motley R., Colditz G., King K., James A. (2020, November). *"I didn't think about me": Perspectives on supportive resources for informal caregivers of Black breast cancer patients*. Siteman Cancer Center Research Symposium (virtual).

Thompson T., Coats J., **Croston M.**, Motley R., Colditz G., King K., James A. (2020, April). *"I didn't think about me": Perspectives on supportive resources for informal caregivers of Black breast cancer patients*. Society of Behavioral Medicine 42nd Annual Meeting & Scientific Sessions (virtual).

Gershon R., Cryder C., **Croston M.** (2019, October). *Risky business: The risk-reward trade-off is different for nonprofit and for-profit firms*. Association for Consumer Research Annual Conference, Atlanta, Georgia.

Croston M., Gershon R., Cryder C. (2019, February). *Risky business: The risk-reward trade-off is different for nonprofit and for-profit firms*. Society for Consumer Psychology Annual Conference, Savannah, Georgia.

Croston M., Kline J., Bish C., Lilleston P., Leeks K., Massoudi M. (2016, October). *Evaluating the associations between structural and contextual characteristics and productivity among a network of CDC-funded Prevention Research Centers*. American Evaluation Association's Evaluation 2016, Atlanta, Georgia.

Kline J., **Croston M.**, Bish C., Lilleston P., Leeks K., Massoudi M. (2016, September). *Evaluating the associations between structural and contextual characteristics and productivity among a network of CDC-funded Prevention Research Centers*. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention's Evaluation Day, Atlanta, Georgia.

Rabarison K., **Croston M.** (2016, June). *How to measure public health Twitter chat participant engagement*. National Association of County and City Health Officials Annual Conference, Phoenix, Arizona.

Croston M., Rabarison K., Bish C. (2016, June). *Evaluating participant engagement during a public health Twitter chat: Insights from #LiveFitNOLA*. National Association of County and City Health Officials Annual Conference, Phoenix, Arizona.

Croston M., Shaw C., Rabarison K., Bish C., Lebow-Skelley E., Henry D., Massoudi M. (2015, November). *The potential impact of PRCs' core research projects & core research partnerships with health departments within the framework of the CDC's Chronic Disease Domains*. 143rd American Public Health Association Annual Meeting, Chicago, Illinois.

Croston M., Chandra G., Bish C. (2015, September). *Innovations in data collection: Evaluation of the Prevention Research Centers Program*. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention's Evaluation Day, Atlanta, Georgia.

Croston M., Rabarison K., Bish C. (2015, September). *Public health, Twitter chats, and evaluating participant engagement: A case study*. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention's Evaluation Day, Atlanta, Georgia.

Croston M., Rabarison K., Bish C. (2015, August). *Public health, Twitter, and the Big Easy*. National Conference on Health Communication, Marketing, and Media, Atlanta, Georgia.

Croston M. (2014, November). *Weight perception and suicide-related outcomes among high school students who were administered the national Youth Risk Behavior Surveillance survey in 2011*. 142nd American Public Health Association Annual Meeting, New Orleans, Louisiana.

TEACHING & MENTORING EXPERIENCE

All courses at Washington University in St. Louis, Brown School, unless noted.

Instructor

Introduction to Public Health (Nanocourse) — Fall 2026
Co-Instructor, Harvard Medical School

Public Health Seminar I (SS55-5910-02) — 2020
Lead Instructor: Alexis Duncan, PhD

Public Health Seminar II (SS55-5920-01) — 2019
Lead Instructor: Alexis Duncan, PhD

Lab Instructor

Applied Linear Regression (S90-6900-01) — 2019–2021
Lead Instructor: Shenyang Guo, PhD

Teaching Assistant

Explaining Health Behavior: Insights from Behavioral Economics 2026
Grading Assistant (SBS 530), Harvard T.H. Chan School of Public Health
Lead Instructor: Ichiro Kawachi, PhD

Epidemiology (S55-5002-02) 2019
Lead Instructor: Angela Hobson, PhD

Environmental Health (S55-5005-01) 2018
Lead Instructor: Christine Ekenga, PhD

Health Behavior and Health Education (S55-5001-02) 2018
Lead Instructor: Darrell Hudson, PhD

Statistics Tutoring

Statistics Tutor, StatLab 2019–2023

Guest Lectures

Croston M. (2023, March). *Health misinformation & social media: Spotting it + intervention approaches*. Social Justice and Social Policy, University of Arkansas School of Social Work (virtual).

Croston M., Evers E. (2019, December). *Professional development in public health*. Cross-cutting themes course, Washington University in St. Louis, Brown School.

Croston M. (2017, April). *Program evaluation, Twitter & public health*. Public Health and Society, Washington University in St. Louis, Brown School.

Croston M. (2015, November). *Program evaluation, Twitter & public health*. Public Health and Society, Washington University in St. Louis, Brown School.

Croston M. (2014, March). *Social marketing: An abbreviated inventory of current research & practical methods*. Public Health and Society, Washington University in St. Louis, Brown School.

Mentoring

Mentor, Donald Hopkins Pre-Doctoral Scholars Program 2025–present
Harvard T.H. Chan School of Public Health

Undergraduate Research Mentor, UMB/DF-HCC U54 Partnership Summer 2026
Dana-Farber Cancer Institute; mentee from University of Massachusetts Boston

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Postdoctoral Fellow, Viswanath Laboratory, Harvard T.H. Chan School of Public Health Summer 2025–present
Lead studies of health (mis)information ecosystems on social media platforms, including COVID-19 (mis)information in Black digital communities and race-stratified patterns of platform use. Collaborate on studies of communication inequalities in cancer prevention, including adolescents' exposure to and beliefs about vaping, alcohol, and HPV vaccine information; contribute to survey and interview instrument development, study design, analysis, and manuscript preparation. Participate in grant development, including an NIH U54 renewal application.

Collaborator, Paths to the Professoriate (P2P) Research Lab — Fall 2023–present
Lead studies that use social media data to examine how anti-Black racism affects Black faculty success, identity construction, and well-being.
PI: Renee Cunningham-Williams, PhD

Lead, Public Health Social — Fall 2020–present
Founded and lead an independent program of research using social media data to study how health (mis)information and its corrections spread, and what interventions might work. Projects include social network analyses of COVID-19 (mis)information and fact-check diffusion on Twitter/X, including within Black Twitter; a case study of crowd-sourced fact-checking (Twitter's Birdwatch); analysis of health departments' network positions and information reach during a public health crisis; and a scoping review of health (mis)information and Black communities. Work has produced first-authored manuscripts, a preprint, and refereed presentations at Sunbelt, IC2S2, CIRN, and useR!.

Collaborator, P4PrEP — Fall 2022–Spring 2024
Co-authored papers examining the influence of health discussant networks on interest in HIV pre-exposure prophylaxis in a national sample of Black cisgender women.
PI: Whitney Irie, PhD

Graduate Research Assistant, Outcomes for African American Breast Cancer Patients and Caregivers — Fall 2019–Spring 2020
Facilitated focus group discussions; revised focus group materials; co-authored manuscripts.
PI: Tess Thompson, PhD

Graduate Research Assistant, #DiversifyTheSyllabi — Fall 2019–Spring 2020
Co-designed a study of the representation of women authors in college courses; collected, sampled, managed, and analyzed data; co-authored a manuscript.
PIs: Jenine Harris, PhD & Amy Eyler, PhD

Graduate Research Assistant, Prosocial Behavior — Fall 2018–Spring 2019
Co-designed an experimental study of the penalties for risk-taking among nonprofit versus for-profit firms; contributed to data analysis; co-authored a manuscript; presented findings at conferences.
PI: Cynthia Cryder, PhD

Graduate Research Assistant, Health Communication Research Laboratory — Fall 2017–Spring 2020
Collaborated on studies of the relationship between basic needs and smoking behaviors; participated in grant writing; co-authored manuscripts.
PI: Matthew Kreuter, PhD

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Health Scientist, Centers for Disease Control and Prevention — 2014–2017
National Center for Chronic Disease Prevention and Health Promotion, Division of Population Health, Applied Research and Translation Branch, Prevention Research Centers Program

Health Research Analyst, Northrop Grumman Corporation (contractor to the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention) 2010–2014
National Center for Chronic Disease Prevention and Health Promotion,
Division of Population Health, Applied Research and Translation Branch,
Prevention Research Centers Program
National Center for HIV/AIDS, Viral Hepatitis, STD, and TB Prevention,
Division of HIV/AIDS Prevention, Program Evaluation Branch

Epidemiologist, Georgia Department of Community Health 2007–2010
Division of Public Health, Epidemiology Branch, Georgia Violent Death Reporting System

PROFESSIONAL SERVICE

Ad Hoc Journal Reviewer

Harvard Kennedy School Misinformation Review
American Journal of Preventive Medicine
Journal of Public Health Management & Practice

Conference Reviewer

Association of Internet Researchers Conference (2026)
International Communication Association Annual Conference (2025)
American Public Health Association Annual Meeting & Expo (2021–2023)

University Service

Postdoctoral Representative, Council on Education for Public Health (CEPH) Accreditation Site Visit, Harvard T.H. Chan School of Public Health (2026)
Community Advisor, Graduate Commons Program, Harvard University Housing (2026–present)
Doctoral Student Representative, CEPH Accreditation Site Visit, Washington University in St. Louis School of Public Health (2025)
Organizer, Writing Accountability Groups, Washington University in St. Louis and Harvard T.H. Chan School of Public Health; two recurring groups per academic year serving 10–15 graduate students and postdoctoral trainees (2018–present)

Community Service

Co-founder, R-Ladies Honolulu (2024)
Alumni Volunteer, Georgetown Alumni Admissions Program, Georgetown University (2025–present)

PROFESSIONAL MEMBERSHIPS

Society of Behavioral Medicine (2026–present)
National Communication Association (2025–present)
International Communication Association (2025–present)
Association of Internet Researchers (2023–present)
International Network for Social Network Analysis (2022–present)
American Public Health Association (2007–present)

METHODS & SOFTWARE

Methods: Linear and generalized linear modeling; social network analysis; content analysis; multilevel and longitudinal modeling; structural equation modeling

Software: R (advanced), Stata (intermediate), SAS (intermediate), NVivo (intermediate)